



VIDEO GAMES are a unique mode of digital media, with no fixed formula to develop one. There is no established science behind game design, no structure behind the development process, no template behind the art, and no core principle behind the industry. Even after 50 years of its inception, the industry still struggles to understand what makes or breaks a video game completely. As such, the evolution of video games has been happening in spurts, with different factors affecting it, be it new ideas that provided a new perspective on what could be inculcated in a game or the tech that powered the games. There have been times when the game industry has flourished very rapidly, seemingly unstoppable; and other times, it just stops dead in its tracks, sometimes even accompanied by a decline. Keeping gameplay fresh has always been a struggle for game designers.

The inception of video games saw developers taking two approaches – games that were inspired by real-life games and others fueled by the crazy mania surrounding D&D. Titles such as *Ultima* and *Wizardry* (both released in 1981), taking inspiration from D&D, aimed to make the personal computers a digital dungeon master. They had genre-defining mechanics such as turn-based battles, story-based quests, random encounters, top-down sprawling maps, hun-

ger systems, dungeon crawlers, and so much more. These games were ahead of their time and were precursors to the RPG genre of games we know today, and most modern RPG games can be traced back to these pair of games. The other end of the game industry was developing more mechanically dependent games, starting with *Pong*. These games were very abstract in terms of their narrative. They were primarily mechanically dependent, with very few innovations due to several factors like technical limitations and corporate greed, which eventually led to the crash of the video game industry in the mid-1980s. Publishers wanted to maximise their profits with a minimum effort and time, resulting in low-quality games and angrier customers over time. Ultimately, the 1982 game *E.T.* burst the bubble, with high pressure on the developers to deliver the game before the Christmas sale, giving them only about five weeks to develop it. Absolute mayhem followed and brought the entire console market to its knees.

When the game industry recovered, it saw several titles that changed the industry forever. Each of these titles set a precedent that other companies wanted to emulate. *Doom* helped in popularising 3D games and

spawned multiple FPS titles. After *GTA: Liberty City*, many games wished to emulate the player's open-world nature and freedom. However, the problem with most of the games with the new emerging market of these new AAA games was that they were highly linear. All the content in the game was tailor-made and was supposed to be played in a distinct linear pattern. *Call Of Duty* downright controlled the game's tempo, while *GTA* followed a very linear narrative even with its open-world nature and the freedom given to gamers. This model of populating content in the game required a lot of resources, teams with hundreds of developers, a big bank and a high development time. And in return, the game had very little replayability value.

The only games that could offer any replayability were branching storylines or multiple difficulty modes. This still required a ton of extra effort with very little value added to the game.

RNG

Let's completely switch gears and talk about something seemingly unrelated for the time being – RNG. The term "random number generator" refers to a computer programme that generates random numbers. A random

number generator is a device or technique that generates numbers by chance. RNG, an in-game terminology, refers to occurrences that do not repeat themselves every time you play. While it



A game so trash, it had to be buried away